



Putin vows retaliation for strikes in Russia

Kremlin speaks with Trump as Kyiv rejects its conditions for peace

BY DAVID L. STERN, NATALIA ABBAKUMOVA AND ELLEN FRANCIS

KYIV — President Donald Trump said Wednesday that Russian President Vladimir Putin is planning to retaliate against Ukraine for drone strikes against Moscow’s strategic bomber fleet as progress in U.S.-sponsored peace negotiations still appears distant.

Following a roughly 75-minute call with Putin, Trump said on social media that they had a good conversation, “but not a conversation that will lead to immediate Peace. President Putin did say, and very strongly, that he will have to respond to the recent attack on the airfields.”

The call came as Putin and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky traded barbs and accusations just days after heavy strikes by both sides — as well as a second round of peace talks on Monday.

Zelensky rejected Russian proposals to end the fighting in Ukraine, calling them an “ultimatum” that Moscow sought to impose on Kyiv, which he said demonstrated that Putin is not interested in peace.

Zelensky said that the proposals were simply “theater” from the Russians, aimed at postponing additional Western sanctions for as long as possible. Instead, the Ukrainian leader proposed that both sides introduce an unconditional ceasefire in the period leading up to a meeting among the leaders of Ukraine, Russia and the United States.

SEE UKRAINE ON A11



WESLEY LAPORTE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Independent Can, a manufacturer near Baltimore, already raised prices this year and will have to do so again, its CEO says.

As tariffs double, worries multiply

BY ABHA BHATTARAI

Tariffs on steel and aluminum doubled to 50 percent Wednesday, adding higher costs and new uncertainty for businesses across the country that rely on metal imports for machinery, construction and manufacturing.

In the order doubling the tariffs, President Donald Trump wrote that the higher levies “will provide greater support to these industries and reduce or eliminate the national security threat posed by imports of steel and aluminum articles and their derivative articles.”

But for American companies that rely on specialized metals that aren’t available domesti-

50% levies on steel and aluminum leave U.S. manufacturers reeling

cally, the order set off a fresh scramble to raise prices and rethink hiring and investment.

“It’s a big, eye-catching tariff: 50 percent is a high number,” said Gary Clyde Hufbauer, a senior fellow at the Peterson Institute for International Economics. “Aluminum goes into all kinds of products — aircrafts, autos, construction — and steel is used throughout the economy, so you’re talking higher prices and lost jobs across the U.S. manufacturing

industry.”

The ratcheting up of steel and aluminum tariffs is just the latest in a string of trade-related policies the Trump administration has delivered in rapid succession this year, in hopes of shoring up U.S. manufacturing. The administration has maintained that the 50 percent steel and aluminum tariffs in particular will spur more U.S. production and create jobs, while protecting national security.

“Nobody’s going to be able to steal your industry,” Trump told steelworkers in Pennsylvania as he announced the new tariffs Friday. “At 25 percent, they [foreign competitors] can sort of get over that fence. At 50 percent, they can no longer get over that fence.”

But U.S. manufacturers say the sudden onslaught of tariffs is making it harder to operate. Many rely on foreign sources of steel and aluminum to make their products and say it’s been tough to find domestic suppliers.

For Independent Can, near Baltimore, the heightened tariffs will make it costlier to manufacture tins for infant formula, coffee, popcorn and dog treats at its plants in Maryland and Ohio. The company — which sells its packaging to food giants including Conagra Brands and Smuckers — has already raised prices this year to offset some of the 25 percent steel and aluminum tariffs that were announced in

SEE TARIFFS ON A16

President plows past warnings on U.S. debt

Budget bill would tack on trillions, alarming some in GOP and economists

BY JACOB BOGAGE AND THEODORIC MEYER

President Donald Trump is pursuing an agenda that would add trillions of dollars to the soaring national debt, ignoring warnings from Wall Street, Republican deficit hawks and his outgoing cost-cutting champion.

Though Trump ran for office in part on pledges to slash the size of the federal government and rein in the debt, his record so far has been less fiscally disciplined.

His administration this week asked Congress to cancel a little more than \$9 billion in spending in the current fiscal year — a fraction of a federal budget that has grown to nearly \$7 trillion. The government has already spent nearly \$170 billion more in the fiscal year that began in October than it did by this point in the previous year.

The tariffs that the White House has said would produce a gusher of new revenue face an uncertain future, challenged in court and subject to revision as Trump negotiates with foreign trading partners.

And while Trump has proposed cutting agency spending by \$163 billion in the coming fiscal year, even that reduction in some programs would have little effect on overall spending, which is driven primarily by social safety net programs.

The national debt now sits at \$36.2 trillion, after sharp increases under Trump and President Joe Biden. The nonpartisan Committee for a Responsible Federal Budget, which advocates for deficit reduction, estimates that Biden approved \$4.7 trillion in new 10-year borrowing, while Trump approved \$8.4 trillion during his first term, including \$3.6 trillion in emergency pandemic relief.

Now Trump and congressional Republicans are racing to approve his One Big Beautiful Bill, which would extend his expensive 2017 tax cuts, end taxes on tips and overtime wages, increase deductions for state and local taxes, and increase spending on immigration enforcement.

“This debt wave coming looks almost insurmountable. I’m not sure why [the Trump administration] is pushing it,” said Chris

SEE DEBT ON A16

Social media frenzy: In 132 days, president posts 2,262 “truths.” A5

Philip Kennicott: Trump’s looming threat to the Smithsonian. C1



SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

A fighter, believed to be foreign, stands guard in February at a site overlooking Damascus, Syria.

In Syria, a balancing act over militants

New leader faces challenge from foreign fighters who helped him win power

BY LOUISA LOVELUCK AND ZAKARIA ZAKARIA

DAMASCUS, SYRIA — When Syrian insurgents rode victorious into Damascus late last year, their rebel leader, Ahmed al-Sharaa, was relying, in part, on thousands of foreign fighters to help overthrow Bashar al-Assad’s dictatorship.

Six months on, Sharaa is president, and the continued presence

of those same Islamist militants, who came from as far afield as Europe and Central Asia to join the revolution, could now pose a profound challenge to his political survival.

Sharaa has appointed some of them to top positions in the Defense Ministry and suggested that many in the rank and file might receive Syrian citizenship, but the Trump administration is demand-

ing that all of these foreign fighters be kicked out as a condition for easing of U.S. sanctions that have crippled Syria’s economy. Shortly after President Donald Trump met Sharaa in Saudi Arabia last month, White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt tweeted that Trump had urged Syria’s new leader to “tell all foreign terrorists to leave.”

SEE SYRIA ON A12

GOP ponders work rules to cut spending on welfare

BY RACHEL SIEGEL, DANIEL WU AND FENIT NIRAPPIL

The Trump administration and congressional Republicans are increasingly turning to work requirements as part of a wide-ranging effort to slash spending on welfare benefits — extending GOP messaging around waste and fraud to argue that many people who get federal aid don’t deserve it.

In late May, the House passed a sweeping tax and budget bill that would impose new work requirements as part of a plan to cut Medicaid. The Agriculture Department is poised to broaden work requirements that already condition access to the nation’s largest food assistance program. And the Department of Housing and Urban Development sees work requirements as an “absolute priority” for rental assistance programs — possibly within President Donald Trump’s first year in office — according to an official briefed on the matter, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss plans that aren’t finalized.

Specific policies could change as the bill heads to the Senate, where multiple Republicans have expressed concerns over work re-

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IN THE NEWS

Deportations blocked A federal judge barred the Trump administration from expelling the wife and children of a man accused of an attack on a pro-Israel rally in Colorado. A9

Victory claimed in Maryland race Democrat Aisha Braveboy is on her way to becoming Prince George’s next executive. B1

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THE WORLD Swift suppression of many of the wildfires across Canada is unrealistic, experts said. A10
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THE ECONOMY Humans are hardwired to blindly trust AI, but there are ways to fight that tendency. A15
Citigroup is dropping a policy that blocked its banking services for retailers that sold guns to buyers under age 21 and those who did not pass a background check. A16

THE REGION The Timberlawn site in Rockville is closer to becoming a historic site based on its link to the Special Olympics. B1

OBITUARIES James Lloydovich Patterson, 91, was the child star of a Soviet film who later lived a quiet life in Washington. B1

STYLE Mike Flanagan, who has become Stephen King’s screen whisperer, is back with a new film adaptation, “The Life of Chuck.” C1

LOCAL LIVING A Father’s Day gift guide for the fastidious dad who loves to clean and be clean.

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